

Architectural styles

GOTHIC

Gothic architecture is synonymous with the Middle Ages. Originating in France in the 12th century, it quickly spread all over Europe.

Gothic emerged from the preceding Romanesque style. While Romanesque buildings were overwhelmingly solid, with massive columns and thick walls, Gothic structures were light, open, and often elaborately decorated. This difference stemmed from several structural innovations. The most significant was the pointed arch, which was stronger and lighter than the round arch of the Romanesque, enabling masons to build higher. It also allowed the weight of the building to be carried through thin ribs and piers rather than walls, allowing for vast expanses of stained glass, which flooded the interiors with color and light.

Building higher meant that structures needed to be supported from the sides. The solution, which preserved the light interior, was the flying buttress. This was essentially the replacement of a heavy supporting wall with an open arch or series of arches.

Gothic architecture evolved considerably, with local variations, until it was superseded by Renaissance architecture (see pp.146–147) in the early 15th through the early 17th centuries. It remained closely intertwined with Christian theology, being the principal means through which everyday life connected with the divine.

Lincoln Cathedral in the UK was the first building to surpass the **Great Pyramid of Giza** in height

NOTRE-DAME
299 ft (91m)

COLOGNE
515 ft (157m)

SALISBURY CATHEDRAL
403 ft (123m)

CATHEDRAL SPIRE SHAPES

A spire is the tapering structure built on top of a tower. They are an important characteristic of Gothic architecture—announcing the presence of a cathedral (or other building) from a distance.



gargoyles represent evil and danger

△ GARGOYLES

Gargoyles are grotesque or wild creatures protruding from the side of a Gothic building, with an internal spout to channel rainwater away.

north tower of Notre-Dame is slightly larger than south

Gothic towers typically house bells

clerestory—upper level with windows

gargoyles act as a warning to those who do not follow the church's teaching

arches within arches

sculptures depict Bible stories for a mostly illiterate congregation

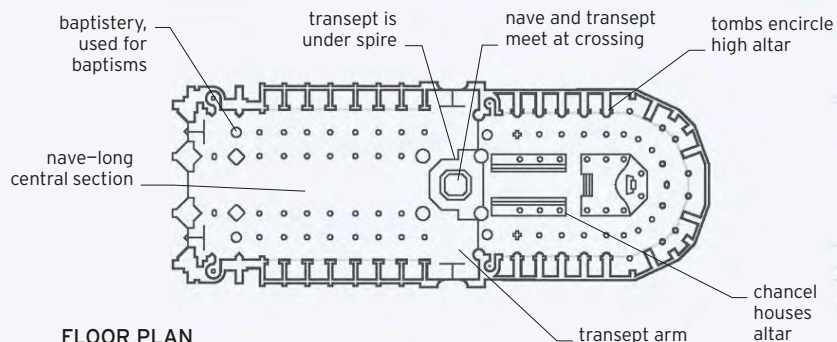
Gothic tympana (recessed spaces) typically come to a point

religious monumental sculpture surrounds portal

peak concludes with a sharp point

shape of arch is defined by circles with two centers
circles have radii equal to arch span

THE PARTS OF A CATHEDRAL



FLOOR PLAN

The floor plan of Gothic cathedrals and churches is usually in the shape of a cross. It proceeds from nave to crossing, with transept arms either side, to the chancel.

△△ ARCHED DOORWAYS

Also known as portals, main doorways in Gothic buildings are often emphasized by concentric arches.

